

Instructor Notes – Activity 4 (Alternative): Unlocking the Impossible (Prompt Chaining)

Overview

This is an **alternative path** for Activity 4 when participants are:

- Saturated with assessment discussions (after Assessment 2030), or
- Keen to explore “what else is possible” beyond assessment.

Purpose: Show that some tasks that feel “too big” or “impossible” become manageable when you break them into a **3-step AI-supported workflow**:

1. **Clarify** the problem and context.
2. **Generate** options or a first draft.
3. **Critique and refine** the output.

You stay in charge as the **human orchestrator** – this is a gentle introduction to the idea of “agents” without building formal agents.

Meta-Strategy: Offer a Fork in the Road

Right before Activity 4, you can say:

“This morning you spent two hours on Assessment 2030.

Quick show of hands:

- Who would like to keep working hands-on with assessment tasks?
- Who would rather explore ‘what else is possible’ with AI in design/delivery?”

Then:

- If there's appetite for more assessment work → run **Assessment Stress-Test** (main Activity 4).
 - If they're clearly saturated → run this **Prompt-Chaining** activity instead, keeping the same slide title: *Activity 4 – Unlocking the Impossible*.
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Framing (2–3 minutes)

Slide suggestion: “**From Assistant to ‘AI Team’**”

Key points:

- So far, we've used AI as a **single assistant** (summarise, draft, critique).
- Many real problems are **multi-step**:
 - clarify → generate → critique → refine → present
- “Unlocking the impossible” = designing a **workflow of prompts** where:
 - Each step does a different job.
 - You stay in charge of chaining and decisions.

Talking line:

“You don't have to build formal ‘agents’ to get value from this idea. Think of it as designing a small **playbook** of prompts for a complex task.”

Demo: A 3-Step Chain (3–4 minutes)

Pick a meaningful but non-threatening teaching task, e.g.:

“Design a new tutorial activity that makes student thinking visible about [**concept**].”

Show a 3-step chain:

1. Step 1 – Clarify the problem

You are a learning designer.

CONTEXT: I teach [year level, discipline]. My students struggle with [concept].

ACTION: Ask me **5 clarifying questions** that will help you design a tutorial activity that reveals their thinking, not just their final answer.

Answer 1–2 of the questions briefly.

2. Step 2 – Generate a first idea

Using my answers, propose **2 different 20-minute tutorial activities** that help students surface their reasoning about [concept].

For each activity, include:

- What students do
- How I'd run it
- How student thinking becomes visible (not just final output).

3. Step 3 – Critique and refine

Now critique your own two activities.

- Which one is more likely to reveal student thinking? Why?
- Suggest **3 small modifications** to make it more realistic for my class size and time.

Explain:

“We’ve just treated the AI as a tiny **team**: one part asked questions, one generated ideas, one critiqued. I’m still the one steering and deciding what to keep.”

Hands-On: Design Your Own 3-Step Workflow (8–10 minutes)

Slide: “Design Your Own 3-Step Workflow”

Instructions to participants:

1. In pairs, choose **one ‘impossible’ or daunting task** you’d like help with, e.g.:

- Redesign one lecture or tutorial to be more interactive.
 - Generate a bank of feedback comments for a common assignment.
 - Sketch out a new assessment idea that aligns with Assessment 2030.
 - Plan a new online module or mini-course.
2. On paper, design a **3-step prompt chain**:
- **Step 1 – Clarify:** a prompt to get the AI to ask you clarifying questions about your context and goals.
 - **Step 2 – Generate:** a prompt to propose 2–3 options/solutions based on your answers.
 - **Step 3 – Critique/Refine:** a prompt to critique its own options and suggest refinements or a small action plan.
3. If time and tech allow, run **one of the steps** live.

Emphasise:

“You don’t need to run all three steps here. Even sketching the workflow is useful – it becomes your personal **playbook** you can try later.”

Debrief (3–4 minutes)

Questions:

- “What kind of ‘impossible’ tasks did you pick?”
- “Which step of your chain (clarify, generate, critique) do you think will add the most value?”

Closing line:

“This is basically what people mean by ‘agents’ – a set of roles and steps for AI. You can get most of the benefit just by being deliberate about how you chain prompts, with **you as the conductor**.”

This keeps the concept accessible while giving more advanced participants a sense of “what’s next” beyond single-prompt use.